

Deep Dive: Benefits that Attract Female Leaders

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OK, when it comes to supporting female leaders, let's take a closer look at benefits. There are a *lot* of options out there when it comes to attracting and supporting female team members with your benefit program. We're going to go over a few options in this video.

We know what benefits you can offer at your organization may differ from business to business, and it may not be entirely up to you. The important thing isn't to implement *everything*, but to start where you are, and do as much as you can.

The number one benefit employees still say they want, including women, is good healthcare. And good healthcare benefits everyone, not just the women, right?

So, let's take a look at that for a minute. Healthcare isn't what it used to be, right? It's gotten a whole lot more nuanced, and a whole lot more expensive. And coverage for a single person is drastically different than the monthly coverage for a family of four.

You may be *offering* health coverage, but how can you make sure your coverage is truly exceptional? Some employers are increasing the amount they pay per employee, that is, the employer's share, to make it more affordable.

You also want to think like a woman when assessing your benefits. Take a close look at the contraceptive health, maternity care, and co-pay parts of your plan. Does it cover prescriptions? What would the average out-of-pocket cost be to have a child under this plan? What is the out-of-pocket maximum for families? Does it cover preventative care like mammograms and other annual screenings like osteoporosis or cancer (which also benefits men)?

Many plans offer a telehealth option that is extremely popular with working parents – you can see a doctor or get a prescription for your child through a quick telehealth screening from the comfort of your home without having a lot of time out of office. Our own company plan offers this, and it's become very popular.

In addition to dental and vision, some employers are adding add-ons to their healthcare options like fertility and adoption assistance – both of which can be expensive – through access to family planning resources. Some employers are starting to offer pregnancy loss leave, menopausal support for challenging health transitions, mental health support –

which again, benefits *everyone*, not just women – and other supplemental insurances like pet insurance, disability insurance, accident or cancer plans, just to name a few.

You may not be able to implement ALL these features in your current healthcare offering but start *where* you can and do *what* you can.

Aside from healthcare, the main thing women say they want is flexibility. This includes both flexible working hours and paid time off.

Again, think like a woman who might have to drop a child off at school or run a family member to the doctor's office in the middle of the day. (Or a man!) How easy is this at your organization? What can you do to make it easier? Because if it isn't the women doing it, it would be the men doing it, right? One of the parents has to do it, and America has become a nation of dual-income families. Gone are the days when most women stay home and the male is the only breadwinner. Studies show most parents work outside the home – anywhere from 58-66%.

So, think about what you can do to offer flexibility to *all* your employees, not just women. This includes flexible hours, options for remote work where appropriate, and generous paid time off. At the organization I work for, we recently went to flexible paid time off. The employee feedback has been amazing, and the productivity has remained high.

If you can't offer something like unlimited time off, studies show women appreciate paid holidays that allow them to be off when their kids are off. Most organizations offer the major holidays, but this means team members aren't having to find babysitters for the kids on federal holidays like Columbus Day or President's Day when the schools and childcare are closed. Your male and female employees aren't having to have discussions about who's going to watch the kids in the morning and who's going to watch them in the afternoon because both parents work. Some companies offer generous paid leave around Christmas – more than just your standard two days, which helps.

Childcare is another of the most popular benefits that attract women. Think of how many women drop out of the workforce due to childcare costs? If you have a family, you know that childcare is so expensive. Some employers offer on-site childcare facilities or offer childcare subsidies to help offset the costs of care for parents who work outside the home – again, a benefit *men* will appreciate as much as the women, because it all comes out of the household income, right? You may see a common thread here...benefits that are good for women usually wind up being beneficial for everyone.

Finally, it goes without saying that you want to look at your benefits around maternity care and parental leave. The average maternity leave in the U.S. is around 10 weeks, which includes paid leave, personal leave, and unpaid leave. The FMLA act requires an employer

to offer up to 12 weeks of leave but doesn't specify that it all be paid. And some women can't afford to take the full 12 weeks without a steady paycheck. It's no secret that European countries like Italy or the Czech Republic offer 5-7 months of paid leave, including countries like Sweden, Norway, or the U.K that offer much more. Even China offers 14 weeks at 100%. So, you want to make sure your maternity leave is generous and competitive in this area.

You also want to offer a location for onsite breast pumping for new moms. Some employers off half days or 3-4 day work weeks at the end of 12 weeks for a certain amount of time to help ease new moms back into the workforce. And don't forget to include the spouse! Make sure you have a solid parental leave policy that doesn't leave working spouses out of the equation.

Again, all of this may not be possible at your organization, but do what you can, as much as you're able to offer. The result of retaining more female team members and leaders is *well* worth it in the long run.

OK, but what if you're not in charge of benefits at your organization? What can *you* do to ensure an environment that supports female leaders? Plenty!

First, we talked about microaggressions – and team members are on the front lines of the day-to-day grind to make sure your department or group is as gender-neutral and friendly as possible. A lot of times unintentional obstacles to females in the workplace aren't systemic, meaning they don't come down from the organizational level. Many are social in the ways we treat each other, support each other and work together. Some of that comes down to how we all *play* together. That's right – play!

When your office has any non-business or social activities, are they thought of with women in mind?

Is it a happy hour after work not everyone may be able to attend, but everyone *should* attend? Or a company-sponsored poker or cigar night where women are welcome but...few show up? This isn't a statement on whether women can't play poker or smoke cigars. Of course they can. The key is, do they want to? And is it really the best team-building option, whether formal or informal?

What if your CEO is female and decided to have a spa night, or company sponsored tickets to a musical? Would the men find that outing super motivating? Some might, but definitely not all, right? What about baby showers that include only the ladies or a golf tournament on the weekend that caters more to men?

These things aren't bad. You just want to think differently when planning social events for your department – especially if the goal is team-building. Make sure if someone is being celebrated in the office, like a birthday or wedding shower, that everyone is invited to attend, and multiple genders help with the planning. The same goes for company events, prizes, awards. Movies, escape rooms, food tastings, tour packages, gift cards – you name it. The world is bigger than ever when it comes to employee interaction and motivation.

It takes an entire organization working together to create an environment that is inclusive and supportive of both men and women. We all have a part to play!

So, think about how you can put some of these ideas into practice today.